

CHM Revolution

The PalmPilot



[PalmPilot handheld computer](#)

The PalmPilot elegantly tracked contacts, notes, to-dos and events, all synchronized to your desktop computer using the included cradle. It was a general-purpose computer used for specialized applications, and was small enough to fit in a

shirt pocket.

The PalmPilot

The PalmPilot was the first wildly popular handheld computer. Its success helped bridge the previously separate worlds of the electronic organizer, the PC, and later, the mobile phone.

The PalmPilot succeeded by redefining the handheld as an accessory to the personal computer, not its replacement. Winning features included seamless one-button synchronization with the PC, handwriting recognition that really worked, easy-to-use organizer functions, fast responses, pocket size, and an affordable price of \$299.



PalmPilot wooden model

Jeff Hawkins tested the PalmPilot's design with this model, using a chopstick for a stylus. He took pretend notes in meetings, and counted the steps it took to perform common tasks.



Model for keyboard-based PalmPilot

Would PalmPilot users really want to enter text with a pen? Palm designers weren't sure. They tested this keyboard-based design as an alternative.

The Story of Palm: Jeff Hawkins

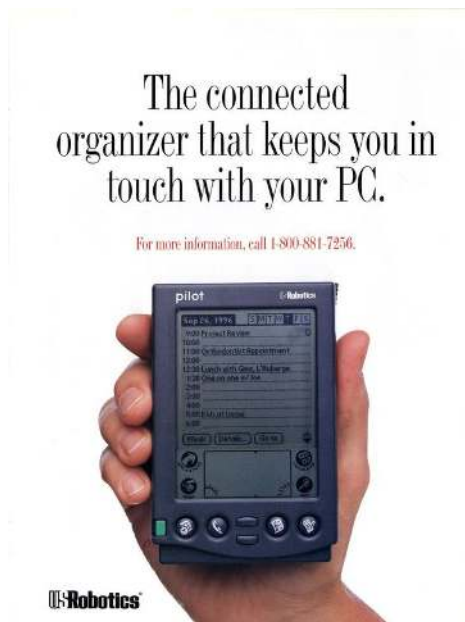
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1. The Story of Palm
2. Main features



[PalmPilot prototype](#)

This “tethered prototype” let engineers develop software for the PalmPilot before production units were available.



[PalmPilot advertisement](#)

U.S. Robotics sold about a million PalmPilots in the product’s first 18 months.

The Bumpy Road to Success

Some Palm predecessors, like the Psion and HP’s LX series, were modestly successful. But several well-financed and much-hyped attempts at pen-based handhelds, including Apple’s Newton and the EO Personal Communicator, failed in the marketplace, costing investors about a billion dollars. Palm’s own first handheld, the bulky Zoomer, also flopped.

It wasn’t a good time to seek funding for a new attempt. Palm had money to develop the PalmPilot, but not enough to launch it, so the company agreed to be acquired by US Robotics. PalmPilot’s surprise success changed the handheld category forever.



[The Story of Palm: Donna Dubinsky: Just Have to Ship the Product](#)

Chapter Menu

- 1. Just Have to Ship the Product
- 2. Troubles Raising Money
- 3. The Pen is not the Point



GRAFFITI

Fast, accurate, frustration-free recognition. Just write on your Newton or Zoomer and watch typed text instantly appear.

The fastest, most accurate way to enter text without a keyboard.

- **Fast.** A proficient Graffiti™ user can enter over 20 words per minute.
- **Accurate.** Using Graffiti you can enter text with nearly 100% accuracy.
- **Responsive.** Graffiti converts each character to text instantly as you write it.
- **Frustration-free.** With Graffiti you take control of text entry. If you want to write with 100% accuracy you can!

How long did you spend "learning" the Zoomer handwriting recognition? A few hours? A few days? A few weeks? Spend 20 minutes with the alphabet below and you'll be entering appointments, writing notes, even composing email with near 100% accuracy.

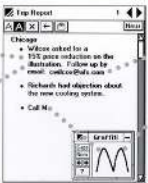
A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z

Graffiti supports upper and lower case the same way a typewriter does with caps and v/c. So you don't have to remember a different set of letters for each case.

Graffiti is designed so that it's impossible to mix up numbers and letters. So you'll never get "4" when you mean "15" or "a" or "e".

Each letter in Graffiti is designed to be drawn uniquely so it can't confuse "1" and "l".

Graffiti also includes **Shortcuts™** which allow you to assign a few strokes to commonly used words, phrases, or even a whole memo.



Graffiti gives you easy access to a broad range of punctuation and symbols like +, !, %, and @.

Each letter is instantly recognized as you enter it into the writing area. You receive no more running out of screen space as you write a long sentence.

Graffiti also allows you to enter text "heads up", concentrating on what you're writing, not how you're writing it.

Package Contents:

- 3 1/2" floppy disks (1.2M disks are also optional)
- Graffiti Reference Card
- Graffiti User's Guide

System Requirements:

- 20MHz 68000 Series 2/PDA Zoomer, AST G320ND 2380
- 10 minimum 68K internal storage space
- PC to Zoomer serial up to 19200 baud (PalmConnect™ cable, Rad-a-Track K25-216 or Coda 1843)

[Simplified alphabet for "Palm Graffiti"](#)

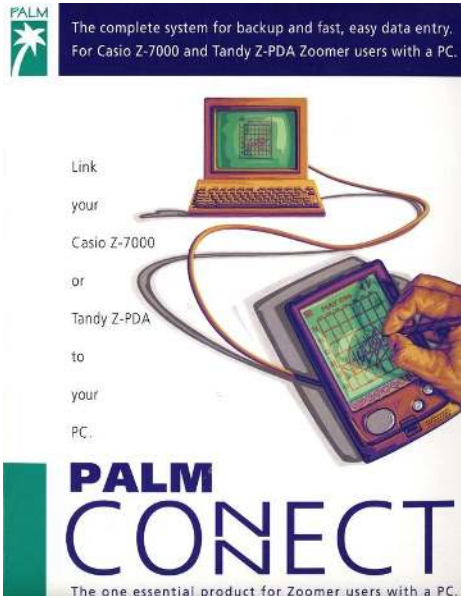
Graffiti represented a gamble that, to improve accuracy, users would learn a new way to write using simplified letter shapes, with every letter in the same box. Experts could write 40 words a minute!



[The Story of Palm: Ed Colligan: One Button](#)

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1. One Button
2. Dialing by Name



Packaging for "PalmConnect"

PalmConnect synchronized data between handhelds and desktop PCs. It gave the Palm founders a crucial insight for the later PalmPilot: that the handheld should complement the PC, not replace it.

Envisioning a Handheld Computer

After designing the first commercially successful tablet computer at GRiD systems, Jeff Hawkins founded Palm to create the simple, hand-held version he was convinced consumers wanted.

Hawkins's original passion, however, was neuroscience and machine intelligence. After a 25-year detour designing portable computers, he returned to his first love.



Palm Computing leaders

Palm Computing was founded by mobile computing pioneer Jeff Hawkins (right), who recruited Apple veteran Donna Dubinsky as CEO and Ed Colligan, formerly of Radius, as head of marketing.



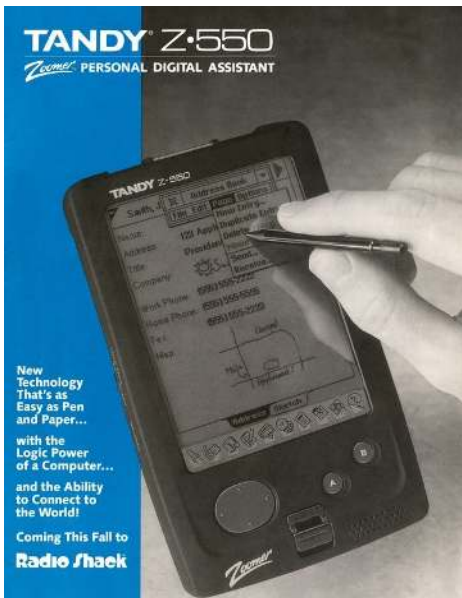
[Casio Zoomer](#)

Zoomer was a joint project of Casio, Palm, GeoWorks and Tandy. It had a touch screen, a graphical user interface and support for third party applications. But it suffered from slow speed and high price.



[T-shirt with original Palm logo](#)

The founders chose the name “Palm” referring to the palm of a user’s hand, not the tree. So the early tree logo was a visual pun.



[Zoomer advertisement](#)

Zoomer, the result of a joint effort between Casio, Palm, GeoWorks and Tandy, was big, clunky and slow. But it taught Palm valuable lessons about what customers wanted in handheld computers.



[PalmPilot](#)

Palm's leaders, frustrated with the unwieldy Zoomer, for which they were developing software, complained to investor Bruce Dunlevie. He responded that if they were so sure what consumers wanted, “why don’t you...go do it yourselves?” The successful PalmPilot was the result.

Keywords

- [Company Story](#)
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- [Silicon Valley](#)
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